return to the homes they had left during the fighting in 1948–9? Most Israelis believed that the Palestinians should not be allowed to return. The Israelis were not willing to turn their people out of the houses they had lived in, and off the land they had farmed, for many years. Besides, Israel would be swamped if all the Palestinian refugees returned and the Palestinians might then form the majority of the population of Israel! Yet, as an Arab information service in Britain wrote: 'Keeping millions of Palestinians without a homeland will amount to leaving an unexploded bomb under any peace agreement signed.'

Key question
In what ways did Israeli and Palestinian views of the peace process differ?

Israeli and Palestinian views of the peace process

The 1993 and 1995 Oslo Accords were greeted right across the world as a breakthrough. There was widespread confidence that the 'peace process' would lead to a final settlement of the Palestinian problem, the heart of the Middle East conflict. Yet, despite the handshake on the White House lawn and the subsequent agreements, there was still deep distrust. Above all, there were very different views of what the peace agreements meant. For the Israelis, the agreements meant that they would withdraw their troops from Gaza and some parts of the West Bank but still keep overall control. They still saw their troops having the main responsibility for security, both inside the West Bank and on its borders. After all, there were 200,000 Israeli settlers to protect. Also, the roads leading to the settlements and their water supplies had to be protected. All of this would require many troops.

By contrast, most of the Palestinians saw the peace agreement as the first step towards the establishment of an independent, Palestinian state. They saw the PA as the basis of a government which would lay the foundations for that new Palestinian state. The PA, however, was seen by most Israelis as a very limited form of self-government. For example, it might run schools and hospitals and set up a Palestinian police force to keep law and order among the Palestinian people. But the Israelis still saw themselves as remaining in overall control of security in Gaza and on the West Bank.

Key question
Why did the peace process slow down?

The peace process slows down

Over the next few years the pace of change was too slow for most Palestinians. The withdrawal of Israeli troops from Palestinian towns was very gradual and, worst of all from a Palestinian perspective, the Israelis kept on building Jewish settlements in the occupied territories. This involved the seizure of Palestinian land and often the demolition of their homes. It also meant the building of roads (which cut through Palestinian areas) for Jewish-only use and it meant more wells sunk to provide water for Jewish-only settlements.

The building of more Jewish settlements had not been banned in the Oslo agreements but, in the eyes of the Palestinians, it went against the spirit of the 'peace process'. It led to the takeover of